

Chapter 4

Manufactured Desire

There's someone you've probably never heard of but who impacts every day of your life and is directly responsible for many of the dollars you've spent: Edward Bernays.

Bernays is known as the father of public relations and was named one of the hundred most influential Americans of the twentieth century. He wrote several works that laid the foundation for how companies promote themselves today.

In 1927, Bernays started working for the American Tobacco Company with an objective to increase cigarette sales among women. His first strategy? To persuade women to smoke cigarettes instead of eating. Bernays began by promoting the ideal of thinness itself, using photographers, artists, newspapers, and magazines to promote the “special beauty” of thin women. He then found medical authorities to advocate for the choice of cigarettes over sweets. It worked. Women started smoking. But there was still a taboo about women smoking in public. Women had just gained the right to vote in 1920, prompting Bernays to exploit the emboldened suffrage movement by turning cigarettes into a symbol of rebellion and equal rights. Bernays started the movement by hiring women to march in the 1929 NYC Easter Sunday Parade while smoking their “torches of freedom.”

That's not the most important thing we want you to know about him. We're just setting the tone so you can form an appropriate opinion of him.

His biggest impact on your wallet comes from his 1928 best-selling book, *Propaganda*. The book explored the psychology behind manipulating